

Plato vs Aristotle



Aristotle (right) and Plato, as depicted in Raphael's fresco *The School of Athens*.

In the early fourth century BCE, Plato founded a school of philosophy known as the Academy. Among his pupils was Aristotle, who had moved to Athens from Macedonia to study with him. Aristotle turned out to be as brilliant a thinker as Plato himself, but the two could hardly have been more different. While Plato thought in broad terms about abstract concepts, Aristotle was meticulous and practical; Plato's ideas were based on a world of Ideas, Aristotle's more down to earth.

As is almost invariably true of philosophers, their personalities are apparent in their approaches to philosophy. Plato and Aristotle held almost diametrically opposed views of how we understand and acquire knowledge of the world, which remained a basic division of schools of thought in epistemology until the 19th century. Despite their disagreements, they had a mutual respect for one another, and Aristotle remained at Plato's Academy for about 20 years, only founding his own rival school, the Lyceum, several years after Plato's death.